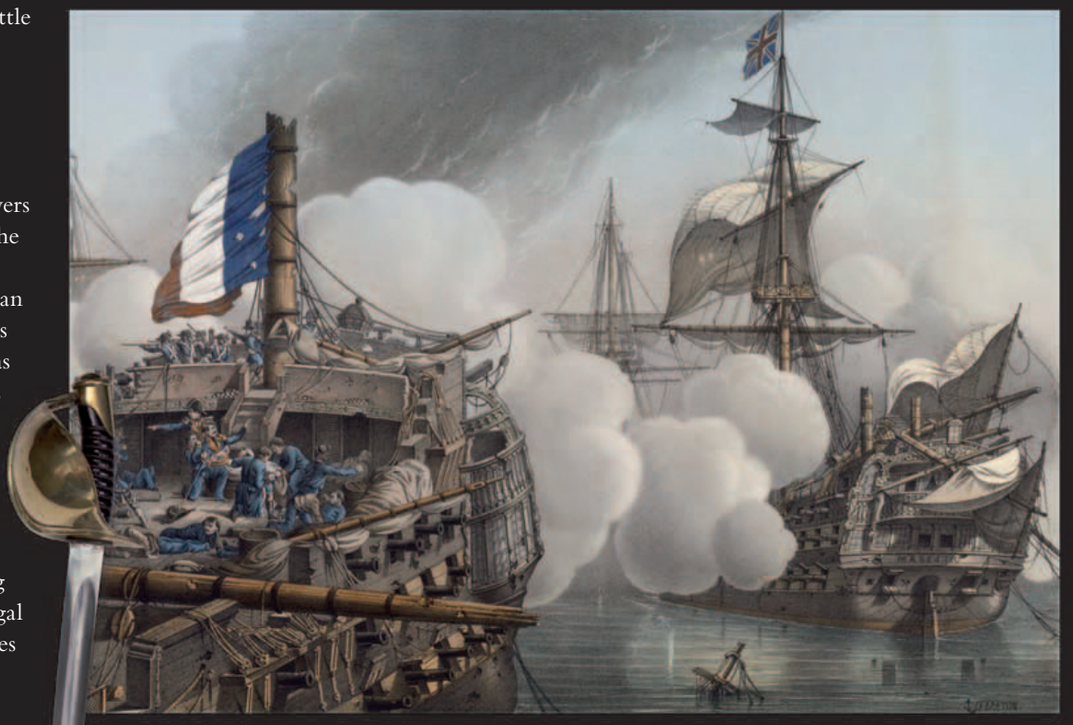
Nelson, whose pursuit of the "pell-mell" battle gave a less formal and more decisive quality to naval warfare, for the most part adhered to the broad principles of the line of battle.

RISE AND FALL

Their sailing ships guaranteed European powers dominance in the oceans of the world and the ability to found overseas empires. Korea triumphed in an intensive naval war with Japan in the late 16th century, but even the Koreans could not begin to challenge the Europeans as oceanic sailors. Different European countries rose and fell in the naval pecking order through the resources they had available for—or were prepared to devote to—their navies and the quality of the seamen they had available to man their ships. Spain was the first dominant naval power of the sailing ship era, especially after incorporating Portugal in 1580. England was one of the first countries to organize a naval infrastructure and bureaucracy, but at first could not match the resources of the Spanish Empire. The Dutch proved themselves superb seamen and built a trading empire in the early 17th century, but they were slow to build a naval administration, relying for too long on merchantmen and privateers. France devoted major resources to naval power under the Sun King Louis XIV, but the counter-demands of land warfare always militated against French concentration on sea power.

By the late 17th century Britain had established itself as the world's leading naval power, a status it maintained—not without serious challenges from the French—through the 18th century, but then triumphantly reaffirmed in the Napoleonic Wars. The United States, founded in 1776, showed signs of naval potential but was still a minor sea power when the age of sail ended.



The Battle of the Nile (1798)
In 1798 Nelson's British fleet defeated the French fleet at the Battle of the Nile. The 80-gun French ship of the line *Tonnant* had its mast blown away, but fought on heroically, only surrendering after the death of its captain.

PROGRESS AND CHANGE

Many changes occurred over the 300 years of the sailing ship era. There were enormous improvements in navigation and nautical charts, in sailors' nutrition and health, and in the design of ships—copper bottoms in particular vastly increased the time wooden sailing ships could stay at sea. By the later part of the period navies fought almost exclusively in purpose-built warships and privateering had been supplanted by the marauding of naval frigates. There was an increasingly formal structure of naval careers and hierarchies. Yet the era holds together in retrospect as a time of extraordinary conflicts and exploits that made naval battles central to the historical identity of European seagoing nations.

US Navy cutlass
The American navy played a minor role on the world's stage, but men such as Stephen Decatur performed heroic deeds with cutlass and pistol, boarding the ships of the Barbary pirates in the wars of 1804 and 1815.

1700 — Peter the Great starts building a Russian fleet

1731 — Invention of sextant: replaces astrolabe as a means of determining latitude

1776 — The *Turtle*, the first military submersible, used against British flagship *Eagle* in New York Harbor

1779 — The carronade adopted by the Royal Navy

1798 — Battle of the Nile establishes British naval superiority

1812 — First steam-powered warship, *Demologos*, built for US Navy

1815 — Defeat of Napoleon at Waterloo

1827 — British, French, and Russian fleets destroy Ottoman navy at battle of Navarino

1700 | 1730 | 1760 | 1790 | 1820

1700–21 — Defeat of Sweden in Great Northern War leaves Russia the most powerful state in the Baltic

1756–63 — Seven Years War: French and British clash in North America and India

1775 — American Revolutionary War: French navy plays major role in Britain's loss of its colonies

1781 — Battle of Chesapeake Bay; French defeat the Royal Navy

1792–1802 — French Revolutionary Wars

1803–15 — Napoleonic Wars

1805 — Battle of Trafalgar. French have to abandon all plans for invading Britain

1821 — Henri-Joseph Paixhans invents first naval guns to use explosive shells

1829 — First workable ship's screw invented by Joseph Russell